

## **Should a Spouse Become Involved in Family Financial Affairs?**

It depends on your family culture. Your younger author's wife has not been a part of our Family Council meetings. That's partly because we've had only a handful of meetings, and we're still getting the hang of how they will work.

Although we would like her to be involved, it's something we still need to figure out. If she is in our meetings, would that give an extra, unofficial vote to her husband? Would family members with spouses then have a greater voice in the meetings than unmarried family members? What if all six children married in quick succession? The addition of so many "outsiders" would change the makeup of the family's governing committee very quickly.

And in the event of a divorce, how is the ex-wife or husband removed from the Family Council and other family office activities? (Or should they be removed at all? If there are children involved, maybe an ex-wife or ex-husband has a right to stay involved.)

These are questions we'll need to answer. And the place to do that is a family constitution.

Writing a family constitution sounds like a daunting prospect. But it really is just a collection of guidelines to help the Family Council make consistent decisions. And consistency—especially in regard to spouses—is critical to maintaining family harmony.

We'll look at this in more detail in Chapter 8.

## **FIGHTING ADDICTIONS AND TROUBLESOME FAMILY MEMBERS**

Substance addictions can be devastating to a family. And no one is immune to this problem. Even the most successful families can succumb to these